

the summer are perfect alternatives to an expensive meal. Shop at discounted grocery stores for the best prices, and go generic when you can. Simple sides, such as seasonal fruit or potato chips are great to have on hand too.

You can also eliminate lunch or supper altogether, and instead provide a table full of inexpensive finger foods topped off with cake and ice cream for dessert. Plan for an after lunch party and wrap up before supper so guests don't expect to be fed a three-course meal. And by all means, let them offer to bring something!

READER TIP:

I use Pinterest to find a lot of DIY ideas and do most of my own invitations and cards.

—Tina, SC

For plates, cups, and utensils, save yourself the hassle and go plastic. The dollar store is the best place to stock up on party supplies, and solid colors are the easiest to use for another potluck or picnic lunch later in the year.

4. DIY YOUR DECORATIONS

There is DIY inspiration everywhere—Pinterest, magazines, blogs—and you don't have to be an expert crafter to try your hand at a few tutorials. All it takes is following simple instructions, and a few dollars in supplies!

For instance, you can:

- Make your own photo props by cutting out printable shapes and attaching them to a straw or popsicle stick. Add a photo backdrop with streamers and fabric.
- Make a paper garland out of scrapbook paper and twine.